

Will we learn anything or change for the better during this Pestilence?

Three requirements for a Christian during this crisis

March 13/26, the 4th week of Great Lent, 2020

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-07_2020-03-26.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-07_2020-03-26.pdf http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-07_2020-03-26.doc

Dear Faithful in Christ: Fr Nicholas and I collaborated on a letter to send you yesterday, but then we heard of more possible changes to the requirements placed upon us. This is a time which demands great attentiveness, patience and flexibility for all of us. Your pastors are not exempt from these requirements. We are trying to communicate with you often, so we are sending you a part of the letter that we crafted with no reference to any changes because we don't know what they are yet.

None of us is being deprived of any grace, and actually, this crisis is an opportunity for us to gain grace. We are resolute, and we are actually excited, because this crisis is an opportunity for all of us to become more Christian. You must plan, and what is more, succeed in your plan to pray more intensely and often. Without prayer, truly the world would end.

There are three main ways in which we can learn to become more Christian.

Refrain from anger, judgment, or saying the word "unfair".

The first is that we must accept what is happening to us without anger or judgment or feeling that we are being singled out or something is unfair. There is endless complaining from many people because of this virus. There is complaining about politicians, and hierarchs, and what churches are doing or not doing, and what the Chinese did or did not do, and the various constraints on our lives, and a thousand other things. God will not hear our prayers if we have a complaintive spirit.

Obedience

The second thing that we must do is be obedient. *Without obedience*, there is no prayer, and the words that we think we are "praying" will get no higher than our heads. We should obey our hierarchs and their pastors who are trying to implement the directives of their hierarchs. We should obey our civil authorities. Obedience is not *just* doing what we are told; it is also not judging and not complaining because of what we are told.

We also **MUST** obey the needs of others, which are just as much obligatory for us to obey as directives from the authorities. The world is full of fear, sometimes insane and crazy fear. You may not have this fear, and may God bless you because of your faith, but there are so many that are fearful that we must consider their psychological and even spiritual wellness by showing them that we Orthodox Christians are participants with the rest of society in taking seriously the danger of this virus pandemic. This important type of obedience is taught by St. Paul in his

epistle to the Corinthians (1 Corinthians 8:1-13). Here is the take-home: “But take heed lest by any means this liberty of yours become a stumbling block to them that are weak.” (1 Cor:8:9)

Increased Prayer

The third thing that we must do is pray more fervently and more often. Prayer must be the *core* of *everything* we do, and must precede and accompany every action we take, but we have listed it last because our prayer is useless if we complain and are not obedient. We have suggested various things to you concerning prayer. We will detail all of these things and perhaps a few more in upcoming letter.

We are getting high-speed Internet installed at the church on Monday. We will be able to live stream services from that point on, and we plan, God willing, to serve every day in the church.

On Sunday, please continue to say the Typica service and read the Gospel and Epistle for the day. If you watch our live stream or any other, please do so as a participant. Stand, cross yourself, pray and even sing along.

We will look for ways to increase our internet outreach to all of you, to strengthen and encourage you during this time. We are open to suggestions from you. We could do live question-and-answer sessions and many other things. We will rely on your collective intelligence to help us decide what to do. Look for more information soon!

With love in Christ, Priest Seraphim and Priest Nicholas

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Church Web Page: <http://www.orthodox.net> Church Facebook Page: <https://www.facebook.com/orthodoxnet/>

EMAIL List: <http://groups.google.com/group/saint-nicholas-orthodox-church>

Typica: <http://www.orthodox.net/services/typica-4th-sunday-of-great-lent-john-climacus-2020-03-29-ns.html> (Complete file for the 4th Sunday of Great Lent, links to doc and pdf file are in this document)

<https://fatherjohn.blogspot.com/2020/03/doing-typika-at-home.html>

Полный чин Обедницы для мирян можно скачать здесь: https://sinod.ruschurchabroad.org/bib_obednitsa-dlia-mirian.pdf

Other recommended Prayers: *A Moleben sung in time of devastating epidemic and death-bearing pestilence. Abbreviated, for use when no priest is present.*

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/moleben-pestilence-reader.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/moleben-pestilence-reader.doc>

Prayers to St Nikephoros: <http://www.orthodox.net/articles/prayer-to-nikephoros-the-leper-during-the-coronavirus-pandemic.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/articles/prayer-to-nikephoros-the-leper-during-the-coronavirus-pandemic.doc>

Akathist to our Sweetest Lord Jesus Christ : <http://stjonah.org/akathist-to-our-sweetest-lord-jesus-christ>

Akathist to the Most Holy Theotokos: http://www.fatheralexander.org/booklets/english/m_akathist_e.htm

Supplicatory Canon to the Most Holy Theotokos: http://web.archive.org/web/20001204003900/http://pages.prodigy.net/frjohnwhiteford/mpthn_canon.htm

Pastoral Letters: This letter: http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-07_2020-03-26.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-06_2020-03-21.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-05_2020-03-19.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-04_2020-03-17.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-03_2020-03-17.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-02_2020-03-14.pdf